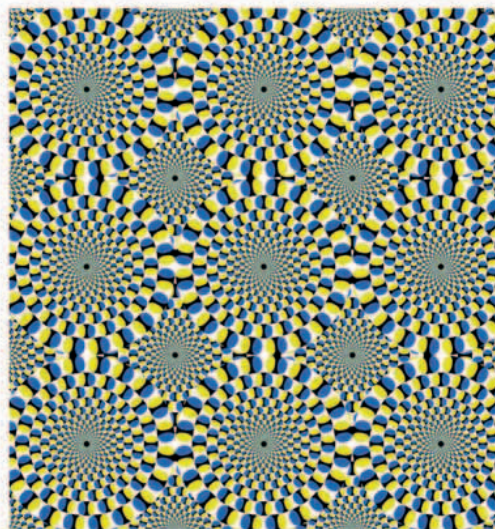


Visual tricks

Sometimes you can't believe your eyes—or more accurately, you can't believe what your brain thinks it is seeing. Optical illusions can jangle your nerves, creating strange visual effects such as flashing spots. Or they can make your brain come up with impossible solutions as it tries to make sense of confusing visual information.

MOVING TARGET

As you scan across this pattern, parts of it seem to be moving. This effect is caused by the light-sensitive cells in your eyes rapidly switching on and off as they react to different parts of the pattern. This sends messages to your brain that fool it into seeing movement.



CLOUDED VISION

Can you see a pig shape in this cloud? That's because your brain is programmed to recognize things that are useful or dangerous. To our ancestors, an animal might be vital food or a threat, so any hint of an animal shape—even in a cloud—triggers a response in your brain.



WALKING TALL

Your brain uses visual “rules” to analyze what you are looking at. One of these rules is that same-sized objects always look smaller in the distance. This makes the more distant figures in this picture seem taller, even though they are all the same height. Try measuring them to prove it.